

Your step-by-step guide to warming up real mailboxes

Written for business users, not engineers. Follow it in order and you will connect your own email addresses — your personal Gmail, your Outlook, or a company address on your own domain — and watch EmailWarm quietly build their reputation so your mail reaches the inbox.

No technical background needed · Read time 15 minutes · Hands-on time about an hour, then a few minutes a day

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PART 1 What EmailWarm does

Email providers like Gmail, Outlook and Yahoo are cautious about new or quiet email addresses. If an address that normally sends nothing suddenly sends lots of mail, they assume it might be spam and hide it in the spam folder. That means the people you write to never see your messages.

EmailWarm fixes this by building trust slowly. It sends a small number of friendly, harmless emails each day from your address to a set of helper mailboxes. Those helpers open the emails, reply to them, and — if an email lands in spam — move it back to the inbox. Each day it sends a few more. After a few weeks, the providers have learned that your address is a normal, trusted sender, and your real mail starts landing in the inbox.

Your mailbox **sends →** Helper mailbox **opens · replies · rescues from spam →** Trust goes up

The three kinds of mailbox in this guide

The mailbox you want to warm

The address whose reputation you want to build — for example your personal Gmail or your work address. The app calls this an **inbox**.

Helper mailboxes

Other real addresses that trade warm-up emails with it. They are never warmed themselves; they just help. The app calls these **pool inboxes**. You need at least two.

Judge mailboxes

Used only for a placement test (Part 10) to see where your mail lands. The app calls these **seeds**. Optional until you reach that part.

Good to know

This is your own private setup on one computer. Everything stays with you; no outside companies are involved in the warming.

PLEASE READ BEFORE CONNECTING ANYTHING

Warming sends **real emails** from whatever address you connect, and once an email is sent it cannot be called back. For your first try, use an address you are comfortable experimenting with — a spare or personal one — rather than your most important business mailbox. Most importantly, your **helper mailboxes must be on a different email domain** than the mailbox you are warming. (The domain is the part after the @ sign.) For example, warm `you@yourcompany.com` and use helpers at `@gmail.com` and `@outlook.com`. The app will refuse to pair two addresses that share the same domain.

PART 2 What you'll need

Gather these before you start. Tick them off as you go.

1 One mailbox you want to warm

A real email address you can log in to. A personal Gmail or Outlook address is perfect for a first run. Note its domain (the part after @).

2 Two or three helper mailboxes on other domains

For example, if you are warming a `@gmail.com` address, your helpers could be an `@outlook.com` address and a `@yahoo.com` address. A mix of providers works best. You'll need to log in to each helper to see the emails arrive.

3 Three more mailboxes as "judges" ONLY FOR PART 10

Needed only when you run a placement test. You can add these later.

4 The EmailWarm app, running on a computer

If a colleague has set this up for you, you only need the web address (usually `http://localhost:3000`). If not, Part 4 shows the three short commands to start it, or you can ask whoever set up the project to start it for you.

5 Two-step verification switched on for each mailbox

Gmail and Yahoo only let you create the special "app password" (Part 5) when two-step verification is already on. Turn it on now in each account's security settings — it takes two minutes per account.

PART 3 Which email addresses you can use

You can warm almost any real mailbox. Here is exactly what works and what to expect for each.

Personal Gmail (name@gmail.com)

Fully supported, and the easiest to start with. You will turn on two-step verification, create an app password, and make sure IMAP is switched on (that's the setting that lets the app read the mailbox). All three are quick and are covered in Part 5.

Personal Outlook / Hotmail / Live (name@outlook.com, @hotmail.com, @live.com)

Supported. Personal Microsoft accounts can create an app password once two-step verification is on. A few older accounts hide this option; if yours does, use a Gmail or Yahoo address for your first run instead.

Yahoo (name@yahoo.com)

Supported, the same way as Gmail: two-step verification, then an app password.

Your own company domain (name@yourcompany.com)

Supported. How you get the settings depends on who runs your email:

- **Google Workspace** (your company uses Gmail behind the scenes): treat it exactly like personal Gmail. Create an app password at your Google account. If the option is missing, your IT admin has turned it off — ask them to allow app passwords, or to enable it for your account.
- **Microsoft 365** (company Outlook): treat it like personal Outlook. Many company accounts block app passwords by policy; if so, ask IT, or use a different mailbox for testing.
- **Zoho, GoDaddy, Namecheap, cPanel, or another host:** you'll need the mail server details (below). You usually find these in your host's help pages under a title like "email client setup", "IMAP settings", or "connect with Outlook". Your IT person or host's support can give them in a minute.

THE ONE THING EVERY MAILBOX NEEDS

EmailWarm needs to both **send** and **read** mail for the address. "Read" is done through a setting called **IMAP**. If IMAP is turned off, the app can send but cannot open, reply or file the warm-up mail — and the mailbox can't take part. For Gmail, turn IMAP on under Settings → See all settings → Forwarding and POP/IMAP. For most others it is already on.

Mail server cheat sheet

You'll type these into the app in Part 6 and Part 7. The app also has buttons that fill them in for you for the common providers.

PROVIDER	OUTGOING (SMTP)	PORT	INCOMING (IMAP)	PORT
Gmail / Google Workspace	smtp.gmail.com	587	imap.gmail.com	993
Outlook / Microsoft 365	smtp-mail.outlook.com	587	outlook.office365.com	993
Yahoo	smtp.mail.yahoo.com	587	imap.mail.yahoo.com	993
Zoho	smtp.zoho.com	587	imap.zoho.com	993
Other host	Ask your host, or look up "[your host] IMAP SMTP settings". Outgoing port is usually 587, incoming 993.			

PART 4 Turn on the app & sign in

1 Check whether the app is already running

Open a web browser and go to `http://localhost:3000/sign-in`. If a sign-in page appears, the app is running — skip to step 3. If the page won't load, do step 2 first.

2 Start the app ONLY IF THE PAGE DIDN'T LOAD

This part needs a colleague who is comfortable with a computer terminal, or you can follow along. Open three terminal windows in the project folder and run one block in each:

Window 1 — the database

```
docker compose up -d
```

Window 2 — the engine (leave it open)

```
cd backend
pnpm install
pnpm db:migrate
pnpm start:dev
```

Window 3 — the website (leave it open)

```
cd frontend
pnpm install
pnpm dev
```

WHAT TO EXPECT

After a minute or two, the website window says "Ready". Now `http://localhost:3000/sign-in` will open.

CLEAR THE SAMPLE DATA FIRST

The app may come with pretend practice mailboxes. If you leave them in, they become your warm-up partners and the emails to them bounce, which pauses your real mailbox. Clear them once, in a terminal in the `backend` folder, with: `pnpm db:seed:dev --reset`. Your real mailboxes are never affected — it only removes practice addresses that end in `.test`.

3 Sign in

On the sign-in page, use the ready-made test account:

EMAIL	admin@emailwarm.dev
PASSWORD	EmailWarm-Phase1-Test!

WHAT TO EXPECT

You land on the **Overview** page. On the left is the menu you'll use throughout: Overview, Accounts, Analytics, Deliverability, Warming pool, and more. The list of mailboxes is empty for now.

PART 5 Get an "app password" for each mailbox

An **app password** is a one-off password that lets a program use your mailbox safely, without your real password. You create one on the email provider's own website, and you'll do this once for every address you connect — your mailbox to warm and each helper. Your normal password will not work.

1 Gmail (and Google Workspace)

1. Make sure two-step verification is on (Google account → Security).
2. Go to `myaccount.google.com/apppasswords`.
3. Type a name such as "EmailWarm" and click **Create**.
4. Google shows a 16-letter code. Copy it now — you won't see it again. Spaces don't matter.
5. Turn on IMAP: Gmail → Settings (gear) → See all settings → Forwarding and POP/IMAP → Enable IMAP → Save.

IF THE APP-PASSWORDS PAGE SAYS IT'S UNAVAILABLE

Two-step verification isn't on yet, or (for Workspace) your admin has disabled app passwords. Turn on two-step verification, or ask your admin — or use a personal Gmail for the first run.

2 Outlook / Hotmail / Microsoft 365

1. Sign in at `account.microsoft.com` → Security.
2. Open two-step / advanced security options and turn on two-step verification.
3. Find **App passwords** and create one named "EmailWarm". Copy the code.

IF THERE IS NO "APP PASSWORDS" OPTION

Some personal and many company Microsoft accounts hide it. For your first run, use Gmail or Yahoo instead; you can add Outlook later.

3 Yahoo

1. Yahoo → Account Info → Account Security (two-step verification on).
2. Click **Generate app password**, choose "Other app", name it "EmailWarm", copy the code.

4 Your own company domain

If it's Google Workspace or Microsoft 365, follow step 1 or 2 above. For other hosts (Zoho, GoDaddy, cPanel, and so on), you typically use your **normal mailbox password** together with the server details from the Part 3 cheat sheet — unless the host offers app passwords, in which case use one. Your host's support or your IT person can confirm which.

KEEP THESE SAFE

Treat each app password like a key to that mailbox. Keep the codes somewhere private while you set up, and don't share them. You'll paste each one into the app in the next two parts.

PART 6 Add your helper mailboxes

Do this **before** connecting the mailbox you want to warm, so it has partners to practise with from its very first email.

1 Open the Warming Pool page

In the left-hand menu, click **Warming pool**. It says "No pool inboxes yet." At the top right are two buttons: **Add via wizard** and **Add via CSV**.

2 Add the first helper with the wizard

1. Click **Add via wizard**.
2. Set the type to **Custom** — even for a Gmail or Outlook helper. (The Gmail and Outlook options here ask for developer keys you don't have.)
3. Fill in: the helper's **email address**; the **outgoing (SMTP)** server, port, user and password; and the **incoming (IMAP)** server, port, user and password. The "user" is the full email address. The "password" is the app password from Part 5, entered in both the SMTP and IMAP boxes. Use the Part 3 cheat sheet for the servers and ports.
4. Save. Use **Add another** to add the next helper straight away.

WHAT TO EXPECT

The helper appears in a grid, first as **pending**, then turning **active** within a minute once the app has checked its settings. A health score appears beside it.

IF IT SAYS "COULDN'T ADD THIS ENTRY"

Read the reason shown underneath. Usually it's a typo in the app password or a wrong port. "Duplicate email" means that address is already in the pool.

3 Add two or three helpers in total, on different domains

More helpers means more realistic practice, and each helper only handles a limited amount per day. Make sure at least one helper uses a different provider from the others, and that none of them shares the domain of the mailbox you're about to warm.

WHAT TO EXPECT

All helpers show **active**. Click one to open its page — it has tabs for Activity, Pairings and Logs, which stay empty until warm-up emails start flowing.

PART 7 Connect the mailbox you want to warm

1 Open the connect page

In the left menu, click **Accounts**, then the button to connect a mailbox (or go to `localhost:3000/inboxes/connect`). You'll see three choices: **Connect with Google**, **Connect with Microsoft**, and **Custom SMTP / IMAP**.

USE THE CUSTOM OPTION

The Google and Microsoft buttons need sign-in keys that aren't set up on this computer yet. The **Custom SMTP / IMAP** card works with any mailbox — including Gmail and Outlook — using your app password.

2 Fill in the Custom form

1. Click the quick-fill button for your provider (Gmail, Outlook, Yahoo or Zoho). It fills in the servers and ports, and switches on IMAP for you.
2. Type the **email address**, the **SMTP user** (the full address) and the **SMTP password** (your app password).
3. Check the **IMAP** section is filled in — same user, same app password.
4. Leave **DKIM selector** empty.
5. Leave **Join the shared warmup pool** switched off for this first run. (It's for trading mail with other companies; you'll look at it in Part 12.)

3 Click Connect and wait for the check

The app now logs in to the sending server, then the receiving server, then creates a folder called **WarmupHub** in your mailbox. This takes between 5 and 30 seconds.

WHAT TO EXPECT

A green result showing both checks passed, then the mailbox on the **Accounts** page marked **active**. Open the real mailbox in another browser tab — a new folder (a label in Gmail) called **WarmupHub** is now there. That proves the app can log in and file mail correctly.

IF THE CHECK FAILS

The message tells you which step failed. "Wrong username or password" means the app password (check for typos; the username is the full address). A timeout usually means a wrong port or a network that blocks mail. Nothing is saved when a check fails, so just correct the field and try again. More help is in Part 13.

PART 8 Check the mailbox is healthy

Before warming, confirm the address is set up properly. These are behind-the-scenes records that prove an email genuinely comes from you.

1 Open the mailbox and its DNS tab

On **Accounts**, click your mailbox. At the top you see its status, score and a trend arrow. Below are tabs: Activity Feed, DNS & Blacklist, Sent Emails, Placement and Logs. Open **DNS & Blacklist** and click **Run DNS Check Now**.

RECORD	WHAT IT MEANS, SIMPLY
SPF	A list of which servers are allowed to send mail for your address.
DKIM	A hidden signature proving the email wasn't tampered with.
DMARC	Your instructions for what to do with mail that fails the checks above.
MX	Where mail for your domain is delivered.
rDNS	Your sending server points back to your domain. Minor, but helps.

WHAT TO EXPECT

Green ticks for at least SPF, DKIM and MX. Gmail, Outlook and Yahoo addresses are set up by the provider, so they usually pass. "Unknown" means the app couldn't check — that's different from a failure.

IF A RECORD IS RED ON YOUR OWN COMPANY DOMAIN

Open the mailbox's diagnostics page for plain-English fix steps, add the record where you manage your domain's DNS (your registrar or host), and run the check again. DNS changes can take up to an hour to show.

2 Run the blacklist check

On the same tab, click **Run Blacklist Check Now**. This asks several public "bad sender" lists whether your address or domain is on them.

WHAT TO EXPECT

"Clean". If something is listed, warm-up pauses on its own and the mailbox page explains why.

PART 9 Start warming & what to expect

DON'T PANIC IF NOTHING SENDS IMMEDIATELY – THIS IS NORMAL

EmailWarm plans each day's emails once a day, at **10:30 in the morning (India time)**, and then spreads them out between about **1:30 pm and 11:30 pm**, with random gaps and at least a few minutes between each one. The very first day it sends only a handful of emails (3 on the normal speed). So a freshly connected mailbox often shows no activity for a while. The next step lets you kick off today's batch right away.

1 Start today's emails now

On the mailbox page, click **Pause**, then click **Resume**. Resuming schedules today's emails straight away (as long as the current time is before about 11:30 pm India time).

WHAT TO EXPECT

Status returns to **active**. On the **Activity Feed** tab, upcoming emails appear and then turn into "sent" over the next minutes and hours.

IF NOTHING GETS SCHEDULED

Check three things: the mailbox is **active**; you have at least one active helper **on a different domain**; and it's before late evening. With no eligible partner, the app sends nothing on purpose.

2 Follow an email through its life

Keep the mailbox page on **Activity Feed**, and log in to one helper mailbox in another tab. Over minutes to hours you'll see:

EVENT	WHAT HAPPENED
Sent	An email went from your mailbox to a helper.
Filed	The helper tidied it into its WarmupHub folder, away from its real inbox.
Rescued	It had landed in spam, and the helper moved it back out — a great sign.
Opened / Starred	The helper read it, sometimes starring it.
Replied	The helper wrote back; the reply lands in your mailbox's WarmupHub folder.

WHAT TO EXPECT OVER THE FIRST DAY

Several "sent", most "filed", some "opened", a few "replied". Opens and replies are deliberately delayed to look natural, so check back later rather than waiting on the screen. The **Sent Emails** and **Logs** tabs show more detail, and each helper's own page shows the other side of the conversation.

PART 10 Run an inbox placement test

This answers the big question: **where does my mail actually land?** It sends a test email to a set of "judge" mailboxes and reports whether it reached the inbox or spam. It needs at least three working judges.

1 Add judge mailboxes ONE-TIME, SLIGHTLY TECHNICAL

Judges are added with a short command rather than a web page. If this part is uncomfortable, ask whoever set up the app to run it for you, giving them three spare mailbox addresses and their app passwords. (The command uses a private key from the project's settings; it should never be shared publicly.)

WHAT TO EXPECT

Each judge is checked to confirm it can be logged in to. Any judge that can't log in is set aside automatically and not used.

2 Run the test

Open your mailbox page, go to the **Placement** tab, and click **Run Placement Test**.

WHAT TO EXPECT

The test starts as "queued", becomes "running", and finishes in a few minutes. The result shows the share of judges where your email reached the **Primary** inbox, the **Promotions** tab, or **Spam**, plus any that didn't arrive. For a new address, a high spam share is normal — it should shrink as warming continues.

IF IT SAYS "TOO FEW SEED MAILBOXES"

You have fewer than three working judges. Add more, or fix the one that failed its check, then run the test again. (The admin test account can run unlimited tests.)

PART 11 Score, graduation & advice

1 Read the score

The score (0–100) is worked out once a day from three things: your DNS health, your blocklist status, and your placement results. The arrow beside it shows whether it's rising, falling or steady. It only counts days where real measurements were available, so the first day or two can look low — that's expected.

2 Understand "graduation"

A mailbox **graduates** when all of these are true: it has been warming long enough (about 3 weeks on the fast speed, 5 weeks on normal, 8 weeks on slow); it has seven days of measured scores averaging 80 or more; and a recent placement test shows spam at 5% or less. When it's otherwise ready and has no recent test, the app runs one free test by itself.

On graduation, the mailbox is marked **graduated**, it leaves the pool, and you get an email plus a short readiness report with a recommended daily sending amount. You can't skip the waiting time — building real trust is the whole point.

3 Ask for an AI explanation NEEDS A SETUP KEY

The mailbox's diagnostics page can ask an AI to explain, in plain words, what's holding the mailbox back and how to fix it, in order. This needs an AI key to be added to the app's settings (it's a placeholder on a fresh install). Without it, you still get a clear list of detected problems and fix steps — just not the AI summary.

PART 12 Everyday use: pause, resume, remove

1 Pause and resume

On a mailbox's page, **Pause** stops all new emails and clears any that were waiting. **Resume** starts it again. Pausing is always safe, and warm-up progress is kept.

Sometimes the app pauses a mailbox for you, and the page says why:

REASON SHOWN	WHAT IT MEANS	WHAT TO DO
Bounce rate	Too many emails to partners were rejected.	Check your helper addresses are real and active, then resume.
Blocklist	The address appeared on a "bad sender" list.	Follow the diagnostics steps to get removed; it resumes after a clean check.
Access revoked	The app password was cancelled or changed.	Create a new app password and use the reconnect button.

2 The shared pool, and removing a mailbox

On the mailbox page, **Pool participation** lets this mailbox also trade emails with other companies' mailboxes. On your own setup there are no other companies, so you'll see only the status change. To stop entirely, use the disconnect option — it erases the saved password and stops all activity. The **Account** page can export all your data or delete the account; only delete when you're finished.

A NOTE ON THE PREVIEW SCREENS

Some pages show sample data and a dashed "Preview" banner — Analytics, Deliverability, Placement tests, Sending domains, and most Settings pages. These are design drafts, not yet connected, so don't judge the real product by them. Everything on Accounts, Warming pool, and each mailbox's own page is real and live.

PART 13 If something goes wrong

WHAT YOU SEE	LIKELY REASON	WHAT TO DO
"Wrong username or password"	Normal password used, or a typo.	Use an app password (Part 5). The username is the full email address.
Sending works, receiving fails	IMAP is off, or IMAP details are wrong.	Turn IMAP on in the mailbox's settings; re-check the IMAP server, port 993 and password.
"Connection timed out"	Wrong port, or the network blocks mail.	Use port 587 to send and 993 to receive; try a different network.
Stuck on "pending"	The connection check didn't finish.	Reconnect the mailbox. A failed check saves nothing.
Active, but nothing sent	No helper on a different domain, or it's late evening, or today's batch was already made.	Add a helper on another domain, then Pause and Resume earlier in the day.
Paused for "bounce rate"	Emails to a helper bounced.	Make sure every helper address is real; remove any practice ones; then resume.
Everything lands in spam	Normal for a brand-new address.	Keep warming; re-run a placement test after a week and compare.
No alert emails arrive	The app's own email sending isn't set up on this computer.	Expected on a local setup. Watch the mailbox page instead; alerts are still recorded.
A plain "404" page	You opened a page that was removed.	Use the left menu, or click Overview.

PART 14 Plain-English word list

WARM-UP	Slowly raising how much a new address sends, with friendly engagement, so providers learn to trust it.
INBOX	The app's word for the mailbox you are warming.
POOL INBOX	A helper mailbox that trades warm-up emails with it.
SEED	A judge mailbox used in a placement test.
WARMUPHUB	The folder or label the app makes so warm-up mail never mixes with your real mail.
RESCUE	Moving an email out of spam back to the inbox — it teaches the provider the sender is wanted.
SPF, DKIM, DMARC	Three behind-the-scenes records that prove an email is really yours (Part 8).
BLOCKLIST	A public list of bad senders; being on one gets mail blocked.
BOUNCE	An email that couldn't be delivered.
PLACEMENT	Where an email lands: inbox (Primary), Promotions, or Spam.
GRADUATION	The point at which a mailbox is warm enough to send real campaigns (Part 11).
APP PASSWORD	A special password for a program, created on the provider's website (Part 5).
IMAP / SMTP	The settings for reading (IMAP) and sending (SMTP) mail.

EmailWarm — Getting Started Guide. Written for business users. Screen labels may vary slightly on your version; trust the screen and keep the intent of each step.